

PlayHavior: A Behavioral Accountability and Reinstatement Support System for Online Gaming

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Abstract

Introduction

Online multiplayer games can have problems with harmful behavior, including harassment, abusive language, and hateful or discriminatory speech. Gaming companies commonly respond to these behaviors with warnings, temporary suspensions, and permanent bans. For example, Electronic Arts (EA) uses these forms of enforcement along with human review and an appeal process to address violations of its community standards. While these actions can help remove harmful behavior from a game, they do not always give eligible players a clear way to learn from what happened and show that they understand how to interact with others more appropriately. Research involving 722 gamers found that a brief social-psychological intervention helped players respond to toxic situations in more positive ways, suggesting that structured learning may be useful in addressing harmful behavior in gaming communities (Zsila et al., 2026). PlayHavior is designed as a tool that can support this process. It does not replace a gaming platform's moderation system or decide whether a player should be banned. Instead, it gives eligible players an opportunity to learn about community standards and practice making better decisions after receiving a conduct-related violation. After completing the required activities, PlayHavior can provide a record of completion that a gaming platform could review when deciding whether a player is eligible to return.

Behavioral Education and Community Standards

PlayHavior is focused on education, not therapy. The system does not provide mental-health treatment, diagnoses, or anger-management services. Instead, it focuses on helping players understand community standards and practice making appropriate decisions in common online

gaming situations. The goal is to give players an opportunity to take responsibility for their actions, learn from the violation, and demonstrate what they have learned.

Research Question and Hypothesis

The main research question of this study is: Can a structured and engaging digital system provide measurable evidence that a player has improved their understanding and decision-making regarding community standards after a conduct-related violation? The working hypothesis is that players who complete PlayHavior's scenario-based modules will perform better on a post-module assessment of community standards and decision-making than they did on their initial assessment.

Methods

The development of PlayHavior is based on research about toxic behavior in online gaming, gaming communities, educational interventions, and gamification. This research is used to guide the features included in the prototype and to determine how the system can give players an opportunity to learn from a conduct violation.

Prototype Scope

The PlayHavior prototype will include five main components:

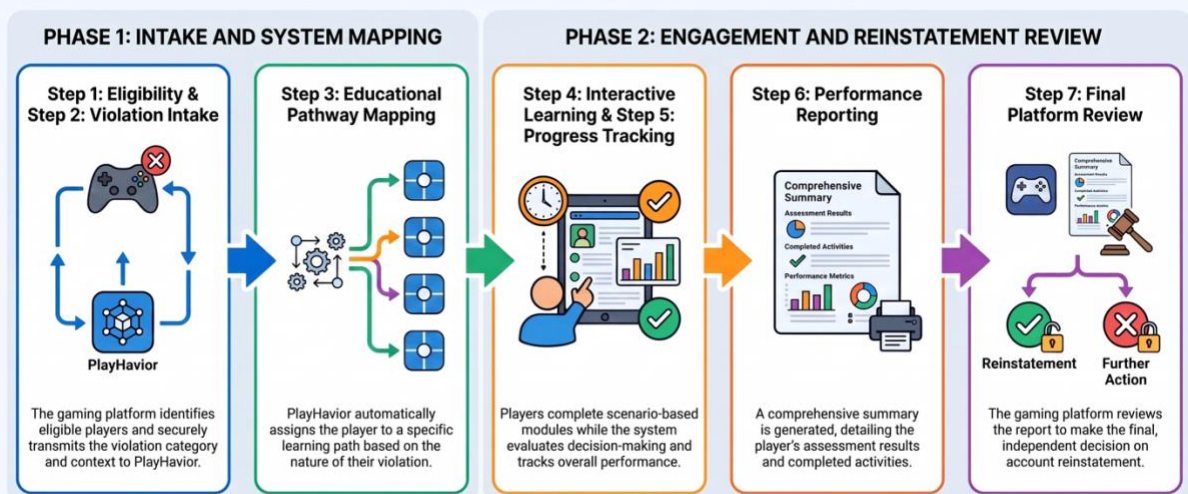
- **Violation Input:** A simulated record containing information about the player's violation, such as the type of violation and the context in which it occurred.
- **Behavioral Category Mapping:** A logic-based system that uses the type of violation to determine which educational pathway the player should complete.
- **Interactive Modules:** Short, scenario-based activities and knowledge checks that focus on community standards and decision-making. Players will be presented with common

situations that may occur during online gaming and will have to choose how they would respond.

- **Progress Tracking:** A system that records the player's progress through the modules and stores their assessment results.
- **Completion Report:** A summary of the player's completed activities and assessment results that could be provided to a gaming platform for review.

The PlayHavior Workflow: From Violation to Reinstatement Review

PlayHavior serves as a companion service to existing gaming moderation systems. It transforms a punitive suspension into an educational opportunity by mapping violations to interactive learning modules, ultimately providing platforms with data-driven reports to inform reinstatement decisions.



Gemini Notebook

Data and Privacy

The prototype will use fictional or test data rather than real player information. This will allow the system to demonstrate how player information could move through PlayHavior without requiring the collection of sensitive personal data. If PlayHavior were developed for real-world use, additional privacy and security measures would be necessary, including limits on what information is collected, who can access it, how long it is stored, and how it is shared with gaming platforms. Depending on the age of the players using the system, additional privacy

requirements may also apply, including requirements under the Children's Online Privacy Protection Act (COPPA).

Evaluation Approach

The prototype will first be tested to make sure that the different parts of the system work as intended. This includes checking whether a simulated violation is correctly entered, whether the appropriate learning pathway is assigned, whether module progress is recorded, and whether the system produces an accurate completion report. The educational portion of the prototype will also be evaluated by comparing player performance before and after completing the modules. The assessment will focus on players' understanding of community standards and their ability to make appropriate decisions in the situations presented. These results will show whether players demonstrated improvement within the activities included in the prototype. The evaluation will not be used to claim that PlayHavior permanently changes a person's behavior or provides mental-health treatment.

Discussion

Results

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Schedule

Weeks 1–2 — Research, Scope, and Setup

Finalize the project scope, research question, hypothesis, and ethical boundaries. Research existing work related to toxic behavior in gaming, community standards, educational interventions, and gamification. Choose the programming languages and software that will be used and set up the development environment. Define the basic features that the prototype must include.

Week 3 — Requirements and System Design

Determine what PlayHavior needs to do and map out the main steps a player will take through the system. Create the basic system structure and determine how the application, database, and user interface will work together.

Week 4 — UI/UX Design and Planning

Create wireframes and begin planning the look and feel of the application. Design the main screens, including the violation input, player learning pathway, interactive modules, progress tracking, assessment, and completion report.

Week 5 — Application Foundation and Database

Set up the main application and create the database structure. Add the information the prototype will need to store, such as simulated player information, violations, assigned modules, progress, and assessment results. Test that information can be saved and retrieved correctly.

Week 6 — Violation Input and Learning Pathway

Build the part of the application where a simulated gaming violation is entered. Create the logic that uses the type of violation to determine which learning pathway the player should receive.

Week 7 — Main User Interface

Build the main web interface and connect it to the application's logic. Focus on navigation, the player dashboard, and displaying the player's assigned pathway and progress.

Week 8 — Interactive Learning Modules

Create the first set of interactive modules. Use short scenarios, questions, and decision-making activities to help players learn about community standards and practice responding to situations that can happen during online gaming.

Week 9 — Progress and Gamification

Add progress tracking and simple game-like features that encourage players to complete the modules. This may include points, progress indicators, completion badges, feedback, or similar features that fit the prototype.

Week 10 — Assessment

Build the assessment that players complete after the learning modules. Create questions or scenarios that measure their understanding of community standards and decision-making and store their results.

Week 11 — Completion Report and Platform Review

Create the completion report that summarizes the player's progress and assessment results. Build

a mock platform-review screen to demonstrate how a gaming company could receive the player's completion information and make its own decision about reinstatement.

Week 12 — Complete System Workflow

Connect all the major parts of PlayHavior so the entire process can be demonstrated from beginning to end: violation input, learning pathway, modules, progress tracking, assessment, and completion report.

Week 13 — Privacy, Security, and Project Limitations

Review how the prototype handles information and make sure only fictional or test data is being used. Document the privacy considerations, limitations, and boundaries of the prototype. Make sure the project is clearly presented as an educational and accountability system rather than a form of therapy or mental-health treatment.

Week 14 — Testing and Usability Review

Test the complete application to make sure each part works as expected. Try different inputs and situations, identify errors, and review whether the interface and workflow are easy to understand and navigate.

Week 15 — Improvements and Bug Fixing

Fix problems found during testing and make improvements to the application. Clean up the interface, improve the user experience, and make sure the database and application are working reliably.

Week 16 — Final Prototype and SDD

Complete the demonstration prototype and make final improvements to the application. Finish

the Software Design Document, research documentation, results, discussion, references, and other required project materials.

Week 17 — Final Presentation and Demonstration

Prepare and rehearse the final capstone presentation. Practice demonstrating the complete PlayHavior workflow and explaining how the application works. Prepare screenshots, recordings, or other backups in case a live part of the prototype does not work during the presentation.

Schedule Note:

This schedule is a flexible guide for the semester. Individual milestones may change if technical problems, research findings, or other circumstances require the project to take a different direction. The main goal is to have a complete, working demonstration prototype ready for the final presentation.